

The first step is the key, but it rests on doing something that does *not* come naturally to most people. The natural tendency in formal communications seems to be to save the conclusion—recommendation, action plan, sales pitch—for the end. Our writing technique, however, reverses that process.

Step One. Make a succinct, one-, two-, or three-line statement of your message; the bottom line of your presentation.

By the time you're ready to start writing you should be able to do this fairly easily. If you can't, the chances are you're not ready to write.

This point of departure acts like a mental funnel, channeling your whole thought process into a tightly focused output. It makes for a stronger presentation because it forces you to focus on your *message* rather than your argument.

Case Study: A client of ours, a research scientist with a pharmaceutical firm, provides an excellent illustration of why this is so important. She came to us to improve her presentation skills following her first experience in presenting to senior business management.

True to the scientific method in which background and data precede the conclusion, our scientist launched into an hour's worth of data related to her projects. After about three minutes, the president of the company slammed his hand on the conference table and demanded, "Do we have a new drug here, or *don't* we?"

For him, this was the bottom line. If the answer was *yes*, then he wanted to hear the details; if it was *no*, the details were irrelevant. If it was *maybe*, he could decide, but without knowing the point of the message, a lengthy exposition was unacceptable.

The principle illustrated by this example is true even when it's not a go/no-go situation, as in the preceding case